NAPOLEONIC WARS

ALGECIRAS BAY



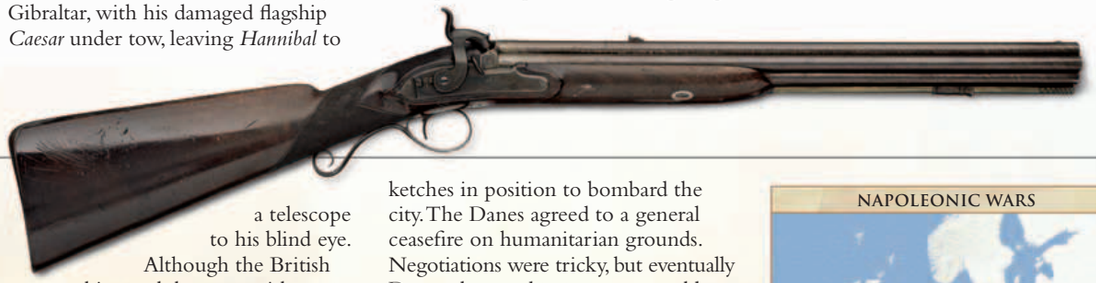
Date July 8-12, 1801
Forces British: 7 ships of the line; French and Spanish: 8 ships of the line
Losses British: 1 ship captured; French and Spanish: 2 ships sunk, 1 ship captured

Location Off southern Spain

Admiral Charles-Alexandre Durand-Linois, bound for Cadiz with three ships of the line and a frigate, found the port under blockade by a superior British force. He moored in Algeciras Bay, under the protection of shore batteries. On July 8, British rear admiral Sir James Saumarez led six third-rates to attack the French, but lack of wind and tricky shoals made it difficult to engage. The British suffered damage from the shore guns and Spanish gunboats as well as Linois' broadsides. The 74-gun *Hannibal* ran aground at the northern end of the bay and stuck. After five punishing hours Saumarez withdrew to nearby Gibraltar, with his damaged flagship *Caesar* under tow, leaving *Hannibal* to be captured. While Linois refitted, one French and four Spanish ships of the line arrived to help him escape from the bay.

On July 12, Linois headed for Cadiz with Saumarez in pursuit. The British admiral had been joined by the 74-gun *Superb*. Fresh and undamaged, *Superb* pulled ahead and, during the night, got between two Spanish first-rates, firing broadsides against both. In the darkness the Spanish ships went on firing long after *Superb* had gone, pouring shot into one another. Both sank with heavy loss of life. One French ship was also captured, but Captain Aimable Troude's *Formidable* distinguished itself by fighting off four British pursuers to reach Cadiz.

Volley gun
Multi-shot firearms such as this seven-barreled volley gun, produced for the Royal Navy in 1795, allowed marines to fire several bullets at once.



opponents and exchanged fire with the usual murderous results—"downright fighting" Nelson called it. The Danes fought courageously, reinforcing their ships from the shore as casualties rose.

Admiral Parker was meanwhile stationed to the north with eight ships of the line. Seeing Nelson's ships in trouble, he signaled for him to withdraw, apparently intending it as a permission rather than an order. Nelson chose to ignore the signal, though most likely without the theatrical gesture of placing a telescope to his blind eye.

Although the British ships took heavy punishment, their gunnery gradually overcame Danish resistance. By 2:30 p.m. the firing had ended, but the Danes had not surrendered. Nelson threatened to use fire ships; he also had his bomb-ketches in position to bombard the city. The Danes agreed to a general ceasefire on humanitarian grounds. Negotiations were tricky, but eventually Denmark agreed to terms acceptable to the British. Nelson was made a viscount and went on to lead a demonstration against the Russians in the Baltic, but the League of Armed Neutrality was already disintegrating.

Close action
Nelson's ships are depicted anchored and in action against the Danish line. Bomb vessels behind the lines fire shells over both fleets toward Copenhagen.

> "IT IS WARM WORK, AND THIS DAY MAY BE THE LAST TO ANY OF US AT A MOMENT."
>
> **HORATIO NELSON**, AT THE BATTLE OF COPENHAGEN, 1801

NAPOLEONIC WARS



THE BATTLE OF COPENHAGEN

Date	April 2, 1801
Location	Copenhagen, Denmark
Result	British victory

COMBATANTS

BRITAIN	**DENMARK**

COMMANDERS

Hyde Parker **Horatio Nelson**	**Olfert Fischer**

FORCES

Ships: 20 ships of the line, 5 frigates, 4 sloops, 7 bomb-ketches	**Ships:** 7 ships of the line, 28 other ships

LOSSES

Men: 264 **Ships:** none	**Men:** c.790 **Ships:** 2 sunk, 12 captured

